



6 Participles and Gerunds



Present Participles

You have seen many examples of the *-ing* forms of verbs being used as adjectives:

- (a) The setting sun painted the sky red.
- (b) This book contains some amazing facts.

In (a), *setting* qualifies the noun *sun*. (verb *set* + *-ing*)

In (b), *amazing* qualifies the noun *facts*. (verb *amaze* + *-ing*)

Such adjectives formed from verbs with the help of the suffix *-ing* are usually called **present participles**.

However, we find that:

1. (i) The meaning of an *-ing* adjective may be different from the usual meaning of the verb from which it has been formed, like:

- (c) fetching clothes (= attractive)
- (d) revolting smell (= extremely unpleasant)
- (e) haunting music (= unforgettable)

(Find out from a dictionary what the verbs *fetch*, *revolt* and *haunt* mean.)

- (ii) Some *-ing* adjectives are used in spoken English only to express disapproval, annoyance, anger, etc. like:

- (f) blooming mistake (used to express anger or annoyance)
- (g) raving lunatic (= total)
- (h) blithering idiot (= complete; utter)

(Find out from a dictionary what the verbs *bloom*, *rave* and *blither* mean.)

2. Many *-ing* adjectives do not have any corresponding verbs because they have been formed from verbs + a prefix:
 - (i) outstanding success (out- + stand + *-ing*; = exceptionally good; remarkable)
There is no corresponding verb *outstand*.
 - (j) ongoing project (on- + go + *-ing*; = continuing)
There is no corresponding verb *ongo*.
 - (k) forthcoming event (forth- + come + *-ing*; = about to happen)
There is no corresponding verb *forthcome*.
3. Some adjectives ending in *-ing* do not have any corresponding verbs:
 - (l) cunning animal (= selfishly clever or crafty)
 - (m) balding man (= becoming bald)
 - (n) appetizing food (= making one feel hungry or thirsty)

There is no verb like *cun*, *bald* or *appetize*. Therefore, to avoid confusion, some grammarians use the name *-ing adjective* to refer to all adjectives ending in *-ing*. Such adjectives may be present participles, or they may be related to verbs, or they may not have any corresponding verbs at all.

Warning: Remember that the *-ing* form of a verb is also used to form the continuous tenses. However, in such cases, helping verbs have to be used with the *-ing* forms:

He <u>is</u> running.	He <u>was</u> running.	He <u>will be</u> running.
She <u>is</u> singing.	She <u>was</u> singing.	She <u>will be</u> singing.



Past Participles

The *past participle* form of a verb may end in *-d*, *-ed*, *-en*, *-n* or *-t*. This form of a verb may also be used as an adjective:

- (o) The buried treasure was found by some children.
- (p) His clothes were dirty and torn.
- (q) The lost child was soon found and returned to its mother.

In (o), *buried* qualifies the noun *treasure*.

It is the past participle form of the verb *bury*.

In (p), *torn* qualifies the noun *clothes*.

It is the past participle form of the verb *tear*.

In (q), *lost* qualifies the noun *child*.

It is the past participle form of the verb *lose*.



Remember that the past participle forms of many verbs, including the regular verbs, are the same as their past tense forms. Compare the following sentences with sentences (o) and (p) given above:

(r) *The Greeks sometimes buried their dead.* (past tense of bury)

(s) *The travellers lost their way in the forest.* (past tense of lose)

Secondly, the past participle form is also used with other helping verbs to form the perfect tenses:

(t) *She has lost all her books.* (present perfect: *has* + *lost*)

(u) *The child had torn its new dress.* (past perfect: *had* + *torn*)

So, to avoid confusion, when the past participle form of a verb is used as an adjective, some grammarians call it an *-ed adjective*.

What you have to remember is that *-ed* adjectives are adjectives, including those formed from verbs, that end in *-d*, *-ed*, *-en*, *-n* or *-t*.

1. The meaning of an *-ed* adjective may be a little different from the usual meaning of the corresponding verb:
 - (i) ***noted*** writer (= famous; usual meaning of the verb *note* = to notice)
 - (ii) ***animated*** discussion (= lively; usual meaning of the verb *animate* = bring to life)
2. The *-ed* adjective may not have a corresponding verb at all:
 - (i) ***armoured*** car (noun *armour* + *-ed*; = protected by metal covers)
 - (ii) ***wooded*** area (noun *wood* + *-ed*; = covered with trees)
 - (iii) ***hooded*** snake (noun *hood* + *-ed*; = having a hood)
 - (iv) ***beloved*** leader (no corresponding verb *belove*)
 - (v) ***cold-blooded*** killer (*cold* + noun *blood* + *-ed*; = cruel, heartless)
 - (vi) ***warm-hearted*** person (*warm* + noun *heart* + *-ed*; = kind, friendly)

Remember:

- The name *-ed adjective* is used to refer to all adjectives that are formed with the help of *-d*, *-ed*, *-en*, *-n* or *-t*, and some of them may not be related to any verb or may not have any corresponding verb at all.
- Though, the *-d*, *-ed*, *-en*, *-n* or *-t* form of a verb, used as an adjective, is often called a *past participle*, we shall always call it an *-ed adjective*.
- The past participle form is also used to form the perfect tenses.

- The past tense form of a verb may be the same as its past participle form.
Compare examples (o) and (r), and (q) and (s).

Warning: It is important, therefore, to find out how the *-d*, *-ed*, *-en*, *-n* or *-t* form of a verb has been used in a sentence, clause or phrase.

- If it has been used on its own, it is the simple past tense form of a verb:
(v) A high wall protected the city from its enemies. (past tense of *protect*)
- If it has been used as an adjective, it is an *-ed* adjective:
(w) You cannot enter a protected area without permission.
(*-ed* adjective qualifying the noun *area*)
- If it has been used with a helping verb, it is the past participle form of the verb concerned:
(x) This wall has protected the city for many years from its enemies.
(present perfect tense of *protect*—*has* + past participle of *protect*)

A State whether the underlined words have been used as ***-ing adjectives***, ***-ed adjectives*** or ***verbs***. Point out the ***nouns*** the adjectives qualify. Name the ***tenses*** of the verbs.

1. We distributed the money donated by Raja among the poor.
2. A divided nation cannot defend itself against an enemy.
3. The cunning fox was trying to escape with the chicken it had stolen.
4. He told us not to go near the haunted house.
5. Molten lava poured out of the erupting volcano.
6. There was a blustering wind and the candles, lit by us, flickered.
7. The newly constructed bungalow looked as beautiful as a painted picture.
8. The frightened rabbit hid behind a fallen tree.
9. Please pick up the torn pieces of paper and find out who has thrown them all over the floor.
10. Jayant opened the closed door and saw a horrifying sight.



11. The injured child was taken to the hospital.
12. The web spun by the spider was glistening in the sunlight.
13. The stories narrated by the traveller amazed us.
14. The menacing clouds were blown away by the gusty wind.
15. The enchanted music stayed with us long after it was heard no more.



Use of *-ing* and *-ed* Adjectives

1. An *-ing* adjective may take an object:

(y) What is the name of the animal chasing the deer?

(z) The man, carrying an umbrella, is the manager of a bank.

(aa) The lady, teaching the girls music, is herself a famous dancer.

In (y), *chasing* is used with two other words—*the deer*—to qualify the noun *animal*.

(Q: Which *animal*? Ans: The *animal* chasing a deer)

However, the *-ing* adjective *chasing* has an object: *deer*.

(Q: Chasing *what/whom*? Ans: *deer*)

Note that the noun *deer* is qualified by the definite article *the*.

So, *animal* is really qualified by *chasing* + (*the* + *deer*).

In (z), *carrying an umbrella* qualifies the noun *man*.

As in (y), the *-ing* adjective *carrying* has an object: *umbrella*.

(Q: Carrying *what*? Ans: *umbrella*)

The noun *umbrella* is qualified by the indefinite article *an*.

So, *man* is really qualified by *carrying* + (*an* + *umbrella*).

In (aa), the words *teaching the girls* qualify the noun *lady*.

Here, the *-ing* adjective *teaching* has two objects: *girls*, *music*.

[Q: Teaching *what*? Ans: *music* (direct object)]

[Q: Teaching *whom*? Ans: *girls* (indirect object)]

Again, we find that one of the objects *girls* is qualified by the definite article *the*.

Such adjectives are also known as *verbal* or *participial adjectives*, for they act both as adjectives in qualifying nouns, and as verbs in taking objects.

When an *-ing* adjective + its object + the words qualifying the object—*the* in (*y*), *an* in (*z*), *the* in (*aa*)—do not contain a finite verb and act as a single unit to qualify a noun, they are known as an *adjective phrase*.

2. Similarly, an *-ed* adjective may be used together with other words, which do not contain a finite verb, as a unit or *phrase* to qualify a noun.

(ab) The goal, scored by the famous footballer, was disallowed by the referee.

(ac) The famous painting, stolen during the exhibition, was never recovered.

(ad) Hiroshima, destroyed by an atom bomb, has been rebuilt.

In (ab), the words *scored by the famous footballer* qualifies the noun *goal*.

The whole unit is made up of the *-ed* adjective *scored*+ *by* (a preposition) + (*the* + *famous* + *footballer*). The unit does not contain a finite verb and is, therefore, an *adjective phrase*.

Similarly, in (ac), *stolen during the exhibition* qualifies the noun *painting*.

The unit does not contain a finite verb and is, therefore, an adjective phrase.

In (ad), *destroyed by the atom bomb*, qualifies the noun *Hiroshima*.

It is an adjective phrase that contains the *-ed* adjective *destroyed*.

For a detailed explanation of the term *phrase*, see Chapter 8, p 46.

B Pick out the **adjective phrases** from the following sentences:

1. The report, submitted by the police, was placed before the judge.
2. The ornaments, made of gold and silver, must be safely stored.
3. The toast, badly burnt, the tea, hastily made, were all thrown away.
4. We were thinking of staging *Macbeth*, written by Shakespeare.
5. The ship, lying in the harbour, will be sailing to England soon.





Gerunds or Verbal Nouns

The *-ing* form of a verb may also be used as a noun.

You know that only a noun, or a word or group of words acting like a noun can be the subject or object of a *verb*. Now, look at the following sentences:

(ae) Reading is a good habit.

(af) I like reading.

In (ae), *Reading* is the *subject* of the verb *is*.

(Q: What is a good habit? Ans: *Reading*)

So, *Reading* (verb *read* + *-ing*) is acting as a noun.

Now, look at sentence (af).

The finite verb in the sentence is *like* and the subject is *I*.

(Q: Who/What likes? Ans: *I*)

The object of the verb *like* is *reading*.

(Q: I like *what/whom*? Ans: *reading*)

So, in (af), *reading* acts like a noun.

Such a noun can also be the object of a preposition:

(ag) He is interested in reading books on history.

(The object of the preposition *in* is *reading*.)

When the *-ing* form of a *verb* is used as a noun it is known as a **gerund**.

A gerund is also known as a *verbal noun*, for it can take an object like a verb:

(ah) I like reading books on history.

(ai) Eating junk food is not a good habit.

In (ah), *books on history* is the object of *reading*, a gerund.

(Q: reading *what*? Ans: *books on history*)

In (ai), *junk food* is the object of *eating*.

(Q: Eating *what*? Ans: *junk food*)

Look at sentence (ag) again:

(ag) He is interested in reading books on history.

The gerund *reading* is not only the object of the preposition *in*, it also has an object: books on history.

(Q: reading *what*? Ans: *books on history*)



C State whether the underlined words are *-ing adjectives* or *gerunds*. Point out their *objects*, if any:

1. Finding fault with other people is an irritating habit of his.
2. I like dreaming impossible dreams.
3. The speeding truck knocked the lamp post down.
4. Speaking with your mouth full is a bad habit.
5. The pilgrims, boarding the buses, will be visiting a shrine.
6. The dentist warned Shanti about eating sweets all the time.
7. Nowadays, many people choose acting as a career.
8. In the past, people were used to walking long distances and travelling was an adventure.
9. Taking photographs of wildlife has now become a passion with many people. It is much better than hunting animals.
10. Harsh loves building model aeroplanes and ships.
11. Buying and selling is what a trader does.
12. You can never solve a problem by avoiding it. Facing it squarely is much better.
13. Charles Dickens was very good at reading out his own stories.
14. Snoring is a disease that can be cured nowadays.
15. He is so fond of hearing his own voice that once he starts speaking, he does not want to stop.

